GUIDE

Fit & Measurement Guide

Learn to read the measurements that make it fit



SIGNATURE CORSET

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> *A corset pattern is only as good as the measurements behind it. This guide teaches you to take eight measurements accurately, choose your size with confidence, build a muslin (also called a toile), read what it tells you, and carry every adjustment into your final fabric. Take your time here: an hour spent on fit saves many hours of unpicking later.*

Why Fit Matters More in a Corset

Most garments forgive small errors because fabric stretches and drapes. A corset is built from firm, non-stretch layers shaped by many curved seams, so it holds exactly the shape you give it. A half inch off at the bust or hip shows immediately as a wrinkle, a gap, or an edge that presses where it should not.

The good news is that fit is learnable. Every pattern in this collection comes with its own measurement chart and fitting notes, and the method below works for all of them. Once you know how to read your body and your muslin, you can adapt any pattern to yourself.

> **Comfort comes first**
> The corsets in this collection are fashion and costume garments. Lace only as snugly as is comfortable. If you feel pain, pinching, or any difficulty breathing, loosen the lacing right away. This guide is sewing instruction, not medical advice.

Before You Measure

What You Need

- A soft, flexible tape measure (fiberglass or cloth, not a metal builder's tape)
- A piece of narrow elastic or ribbon to tie around the natural waist
- A mirror, or better, a helper
- Pencil and the fitting notebook at the end of this guide
- Form-fitting, thin clothing: a plain camisole and leggings, or a thin bodysuit

How to Prepare

1. Stand tall and relaxed in your normal posture, feet together, weight even on both feet.
2. Breathe normally. Do not hold your breath or pull the tape tight; the tape should lie flat and snug but not dent the skin.
3. Wear the undergarments you plan to wear under the finished corset, usually a thin bra or none, and a seamless camisole.
4. Keep the tape parallel to the floor for every circumference measurement. Check in the mirror.
5. Measure twice, write down both numbers, and use the larger one if they differ by less than a quarter inch.

The Eight Measurements, Step by Step

Take the measurements in the order below, because several of them depend on the one before. Record each in inches. If you also like to work in centimeters, multiply inches by 2.54.

1. Bust

Wrap the tape around the fullest part of your bust, passing over the nipple line and straight across the back at the same height. Keep the tape level; it often drifts lower at the back, so check in the mirror.

> **Tip**
> Wear the bra you will actually wear with the corset. A different bra can change this number by an inch or more.

2. Underbust

Raise your arms slightly, find the crease where the bust meets the ribcage, and wrap the tape snugly there. This is where the top edge of an underbust corset sits, so it matters a great deal. Lower your arms and recheck that the tape has not slipped.

3. Natural Waist

Tie the elastic around your middle, bend side to side, and let it settle into the crease. That is your natural waist, the narrowest point of the torso. Remove your hands and measure over the elastic, snug but not compressing. Leave the elastic in place for the next measurements.

> **Tip**
> Your natural waist is usually higher than where trousers sit. If the elastic wants to roll down, you have found the right spot only when it stays put on its own.

4. High Hip

The high hip is the shelf of the upper pelvis, about 3 to 4 inches below the natural waist. Measure around the fullest point of that area, keeping the tape level. Many corset patterns use this number for the bottom edge of a short or waist-length style, so do not skip it.

5. Hip

Measure around the fullest part of the hips and seat, usually about 7 to 9 inches below the natural waist. Stand with feet together; a wide stance gives a falsely large number. If you have a rounder seat or fuller thighs, check that the tape is at the widest point, not just a standard distance down.

6. Torso: Underbust to Waist

This is a vertical measurement. Measure straight down your side from the underbust line to the elastic at the natural waist. It tells you how much length you have between the two points, and it is the key measurement for deciding whether a pattern needs to be lengthened or shortened.

Take it on both sides and at the center front. If the numbers differ, use the average and note the difference in your notebook; many people are slightly asymmetrical, and that is perfectly normal.

7. Waist to Hip

Measure vertically from the elastic at the natural waist down the side of the body to the level of the fullest hip. This tells you how far down the hip curve begins. A shorter waist-to-hip distance means the curve is steeper, which affects how the lower panels need to be shaped.

8. Center-Front Length

Measure straight down the center front of the body from where the top edge of the corset will sit to where the bottom edge will end. For an underbust style, start at the underbust line; for an overbust style, start at the point you want the neckline to be. Keep the tape flat against the body rather than stretching it over the bust.

> **Tip**
> Sit down and check this length again. If the bottom edge would dig into your thighs or lower belly when seated, shorten the length by a half inch or so before you cut.

Quick Reference

MEASUREMENT	WHERE TO MEASURE	DIRECTION
Bust	Fullest part of the bust	Around
Underbust	Crease below the bust	Around
Natural waist	Narrowest point, found with elastic	Around
High hip	3 to 4 in below the waist	Around
Hip	Fullest part of hips and seat	Around
Underbust to waist	Underbust line down to the waist elastic	Vertical
Waist to hip	Waist elastic down to fullest hip	Vertical
Center-front length	Top edge to bottom edge of the corset, center front	Vertical

The Size Chart: XS to 2XL

The chart below gives body measurements in inches for each size. These are the measurements of the person, not of the finished corset, which will be smaller at the waist. Use these numbers to compare yourself with the chart printed on each individual pattern.

SIZE	BUST	UNDERBUST	WAIST	HIGH HIP	HIP
XS	32	27	24	33	35
S	34	29	26	35	37
M	36	31	28	37	39
L	38	33	30	39	41
XL	40	35	32	41	43
2XL	42	37	34	43	45

Each size steps up by 2 inches in every measurement. That consistency makes it easy to see where you fall, and it also makes it simple to blend sizes, as the next section explains.

Choosing Your Size

Start With the Waist and Underbust

For a corset, the waist and the underbust are the most important numbers, because those are where the garment hugs hardest. Find the size whose waist and underbust are closest to yours. Then check the bust and hips: if they sit in a different size, you will blend sizes or adjust the muslin.

If You Are Between Two Sizes

Being between sizes is the rule, not the exception. Use this order of decisions.

1. If your waist falls between two sizes, choose the larger size and plan to take in at the back seam during the muslin fitting. It is far easier to remove fabric than to add it.
2. If your bust or hip is larger than your waist size suggests, cut the muslin in your waist size and grade out to the larger size at the bust or hip panels, tapering smoothly between them.
3. If your underbust is between sizes, choose the larger one; a top edge that is too tight at the ribs is the most common comfort complaint.
4. If you plan to wear the corset over several layers, such as a blouse, choose the larger size and check that the muslin closes comfortably over those layers.

Example

Your measurements are bust 37, underbust 31, waist 27, hip 40. The waist sits between S (26) and M (28), the bust and underbust match M, and the hip falls between M (39) and L (41). Start with M, expect to take in a little at the back seam, and check the hip panels in the muslin.

Understanding Reduction

A corset is normally made a little smaller than the body at the waist. This difference between your natural waist and the finished waist of the corset is called the reduction. It gives the garment its shape and keeps it from sliding, but it should be modest and comfortable.

For these patterns, a comfortable reduction is about 2 to 3 inches at the waist. Many people prefer 2 inches or even less, especially for a first corset or a corset worn for several hours. There is no reward for going smaller, and forcing the numbers leads to discomfort and poor fit.

SIZE	NATURAL WAIST	REDUCTION	FINISHED CORSET WAIST (CLOSED)
XS	24 in	2 in	22 in
S	26 in	2 in	24 in
M	28 in	2.5 in	25.5 in
L	30 in	2.5 in	27.5 in
XL	32 in	3 in	29 in
2XL	34 in	3 in	31 in

The numbers above are examples of comfortable reductions, not targets. The patterns in this collection are drafted with this modest shaping already built in, so you do not need to subtract more yourself. Your muslin will tell you whether the result feels right.

No forcing

These patterns are not designed for waist training or extreme shaping. Choose a reduction that lets you sit, breathe, and move comfortably. If you are unsure, go smaller on the reduction, not larger.

The Lacing Gap

The back of a corset closes with laces, and the two back edges do not meet in the middle. The space between them at the waist is the lacing gap. A gap of about 2 inches when the corset is laced comfortably closed is the standard target for these patterns.

How to Measure the Gap

1. Put on the corset (or the muslin) and lace it snugly but comfortably, the way you would wear it.
2. Stand relaxed. Do not hold your breath.
3. Measure straight across the back from one lacing edge to the other at the waist level, using a ruler or the tape.
4. Record the number in your fitting notebook.

What the Gap Tells You

GAP AT THE WAIST	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT TO DO
About 2 in	Good fit, with room to loosen or tighten	Keep the pattern as drafted
More than 3 in	Corset is too large	Take in at the back seam or use a smaller size
Less than 1 in, or edges touching	Corset is too small	Let out at the back or choose a larger size
Wider at the top than the bottom	Back is too loose at the bust	Take in the top of the back panel
Wider at the bottom than the top	Hip panels are too loose, or too tight at the bust	Check the hip panels, then the bust

A parallel gap, the same width from top to bottom, is the sign of a well-fitted back. The edges should run roughly straight and not form a V or an inverted V.

Comparing Your Measurements With the Pattern Chart

Every pattern in the collection comes with its own measurement chart. These charts list the body measurements the pattern was drafted for, along with the finished corset measurements. Take a few minutes to read the chart before you print or cut anything.

1. Find your row in the chart by waist and underbust first.
2. Compare each of your eight measurements with that row. Note the difference for each, in inches, as plus or minus.
3. Compare your vertical measurements (underbust to waist, waist to hip, center-front length) with the pattern's finished lengths.
4. Mark any differences larger than half an inch in your fitting notebook. Those are the places you will test in the muslin.

Differences under a quarter inch can usually be ignored. Differences of half an inch to an inch are typically handled with small adjustments at the seams. Anything over an inch is a signal to try a different size or a different style of corset.

A note on ease

A corset has no stretch, so the pattern already includes the right shaping. Do not add extra ease to your measurements before comparing; use your actual body numbers.

Making the Muslin (Toile)

A muslin, also called a toile, is a trial version of the corset made from inexpensive fabric. It lets you test the fit before you cut into your good fabric, and it is the single most valuable step in the process. Always make one, even for a pattern you have used before, because your body and the fabric both change.

Materials

- Cotton coutil, sturdy cotton twill, or heavy cotton canvas as close to the weight of your final fabric as you can
- Cotton thread in a contrasting color, so you can see your stitches
- Temporary boning: cable ties, cardboard strips, or plastic boning cut to length
- Lacing cord and two sets of grommets or eyelets, or simply a long ribbon threaded through large holes
- A fabric marker or chalk, a fine pen, and a ruler

Step 1: Cut

Print the pattern at full scale and check the test square. Add seam allowances if the pattern does not include them. Cut each panel from the muslin fabric with the grain line running straight up and down, exactly as you will on the final fabric. Mark the waist, the bust line, and the hip line on every panel.

Step 2: Mark

Transfer the seam lines to the fabric with a fine pen or tailor's chalk. Mark the notches, the boning channels, and the center back. Write the panel numbers on each piece, so that you can keep them in the right order.

Step 3: Assemble With a Long Stitch

Sew the panels together with a long stitch, around 4 mm or 5 on most machines, and without backstitching. A long stitch is strong enough for fitting but easy to unpick when you need to make changes. Press the seams open and flat.

Tip

Sew the seams in the order the pattern gives, starting from the center front and working toward the back. This keeps the shaping accurate and the panels from twisting.

Step 4: Add Temporary Boning and Lacing

Slip temporary boning into the channels, or tape it along the seam lines, so the muslin holds its shape. Add a simple closure at the back, either grommets or a pinned fold, and lace it up loosely at first. Without boning the muslin will collapse and mislead you.

Step 5: Try It On

Put on the muslin over your usual undergarments and lace it so it feels comfortable. Stand in front of a mirror, preferably with a helper to check the back. Walk around, sit down, raise your arms, and breathe deeply. How it behaves while you move is as important as how it looks standing still.

> **Stop if it hurts**
>
> A muslin should feel snug, never painful. If anything pinches or you feel short of breath, loosen it at once. A fitting is not a test of endurance.

Step 6: Mark the Adjustments

With the muslin on, use a fabric marker or pins to note every problem directly on the fabric. Mark where the fabric wrinkles, gaps, or digs; where the top and bottom edges sit; and where the waist line lands compared with your natural waist. Photograph the front, side, and back. Then take it off and work through the adjustments one at a time.

Common Adjustments

ADJUSTMENT	HOW TO MAKE IT ON THE MUSLIN
Torso too long	Mark the new bottom or top edge, then fold out the excess across all panels at the same height
Torso too short	Slash across the panels above the waist, spread the needed amount, and tape in a strip of paper
Panel too wide	Pin out the excess along the side seams of that panel, equally on both edges
Panel too narrow	Add a strip of paper at the seam and redraw the seam line smoothly
Hips too tight	Let out the side seam below the waist, tapering to nothing at the waist
Hips too loose	Take in the side seam from waist to hip, tapering to nothing at the waist
Bust too tight	Let out the seams in the bust panels, or move to a larger size at the bust
Bust too loose	Take in the bust panel seams, or use a slightly smaller bust cup shape

Make only one or two changes at a time, and remake the muslin if the changes are large. Two quick rounds of fitting give you a better result than one round with a lot of guesses.

Fit Problems: Causes and Solutions

Almost every fit problem shows up in one of four ways. Use this table to read what your muslin is telling you.

PROBLEM	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	LIKELY CAUSE	SOLUTION
Wrinkles	Diagonal or horizontal folds pointing toward the area that is tight	Panel too small in that area, or not enough boning	Let out the seam where the folds point; check that the boning reaches the full length of the panel
Wrinkles at the waist	Horizontal folds across the waist	Corset is too long or the waist is too large	Shorten the torso length or take in at the waist seams
Gaping at the top	Top edge stands away from the body at the bust or back	Top panels too large, or bust shaping off	Take in at the top of the seams, or add a small dart
Gaping at the bust	Space between the cup area and the bust	Cup is too large or the underbust is too loose	Reduce the bust curve; check the underbust measurement
Digging at the top	Top edge presses into the ribs or underarm	Top edge too high or too tight	Lower the top edge by a half to one inch, and ease the curve
Digging at the bottom	Bottom edge presses into the hip or thigh	Bottom edge too long or hips too tight	Shorten the bottom, or add room at the hip seams
Digging at the waist	Pressure at the waist line	Waist too small or reduction too aggressive	Let out the waist seams; choose a smaller reduction
Riding up	Corset slides up the body when you sit or move	Hip curve too narrow, or not enough grip at the hip	Add room at the hip, or lengthen the lower panels slightly
Riding down	Corset slides down the ribs	Underbust too loose, or waist shaping too shallow	Take in at the underbust; check the waist position
Back gap uneven	Edges form a V or an inverted V	Back panel too wide or too narrow at one end	Adjust the back panel at the narrower end until the gap is parallel

> **Read the folds**
>
> Wrinkles point toward the problem. A fold that runs from the hip up toward the waist usually means the hip area is tight; a fold that runs toward the bust usually means the bust is tight. Follow the fold and let that area out slightly.

Transferring Adjustments to the Pattern

Once the muslin fits, do not leave the changes on the fabric. Move them to the paper pattern, so every future corset you cut comes out right the first time.

1. Unpick the muslin and press each panel flat. Mark the new seam lines and edges with a pen.
2. Lay the muslin panel on top of the original paper pattern, matching the grain line and the waist line.
3. Trace the new seam lines, edges, and any changes in length onto the paper. If you added width, tape extra paper to the pattern first.
4. Redraw each line smoothly with a curved ruler, so the seams flow in one curve instead of a series of angles.
5. Check that the seams that join together are the same length. Walk the tape along each seam and compare the measurements; adjust until they match.
6. Label the new pattern with your name for it, the date, and the size and changes, such as M with 1 in added to the torso.

> **Keep the original**
> Always trace the adjusted pattern onto new paper, or print a fresh copy. Keep the unmarked original in a folder, in case you want to make a different size later.

Carrying the Fit to Your Final Fabric

Your final fabric may behave a little differently from the muslin. Heavier coutil, brocade, or a layer of lining and interlining can take up a fraction of an inch. These steps help you keep the fit you worked for.

- Cut the final fabric with the same grain line and the same seam allowances you used in the muslin.
- Transfer all the markings, waist line, bust line, hip line, and notches, using tailor's tacks or a washable marker.
- Sew a sample seam in the final fabric and measure it. If it comes out larger or smaller than the muslin, adjust the seam allowance slightly.
- Assemble the corset in stages, and try it on after the main seams are sewn but before the boning and binding go in.
- Press each seam well, because pressing sets the shape and affects the final measurement.
- Keep your muslin. It is a perfect reference and a convenient record of your fit.

If you are using a very different fabric, such as sheer tulle or a thick brocade, make a second muslin in a fabric with a similar weight. The Sheer Tulle Handling Guide in your bonus folder gives more advice on this.

Safety and Comfort Reminders

- Lace only as snugly as is comfortable. A corset is a garment, not a contest.
- If you feel pain, pinching, numbness, dizziness, or difficulty breathing, loosen or remove the corset right away.
- Do not wear a new corset for long stretches at first. Start with an hour or two and build up if it feels good.
- Never pull the laces to meet a number. Your muslin and your comfort decide the size.

- Listen to your body on any given day; bodies change with the time of day, the season, and the day of the month, and that is normal.
- These patterns are for fashion, costume, and special-occasion garments. They are not designed for waist training, tight lacing, or any health or body-shaping purpose.
- If you have a medical condition or any concern about wearing a corset, speak with a qualified professional. This guide is not medical advice.

Your Fitting Notebook

Copy this page or rewrite it in a notebook. Fill it in once with your own measurements, then add a new row each time you make a muslin. Over time it becomes the most useful reference you own.

My Measurements

MEASUREMENT	DATE: _____	DATE: _____	NOTES
Bust			
Underbust			
Natural waist			
High hip			
Hip			
Underbust to waist			
Waist to hip			
Center-front length			
Lacing gap (muslin)			

Muslin Log

PATTERN	SIZE	FABRIC	PROBLEM FOUND	ADJUSTMENT MADE	RESULT

FIT CHECKLIST BEFORE YOU CUT THE FINAL FABRIC

☐ I took all eight measurements and recorded them in inches

☐ I compared my numbers with the pattern's chart and noted differences

☐ I made a muslin in a fabric close to the weight of my final fabric

☐ I tried it on with boning and lacing, sitting and standing

☐ The lacing gap is about 2 inches and parallel

☐ No wrinkles, gaping, digging, or riding up that I could not solve

☐ I transferred every adjustment to a fresh copy of the pattern

☐ I labeled the adjusted pattern with the date, size, and changes

☐ I confirmed the corset is comfortable to breathe, sit, and move in

Next Step

Choose the pattern you most want to make, take your eight measurements, and write them in the notebook above. Then print the pattern, cut your muslin, and give yourself one calm hour to fit it. When it feels right, you are ready for the final fabric and the finishing techniques that make a corset truly your own.